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GovTech 2026 Hackathon Adjudication Criteria

1. Relevance to the Challenge Statement (20%)

Does the solution effectively address the challenge and its core requirements?

Judges will assess how effectively the solution responds to the challenge statement, addresses the identified problem, and delivers meaningful value to the department.

Where all requirements have not been fully implemented, judges may consider the extent to which the proposed approach addresses the most important requirements and demonstrates a credible path to delivering the broader solution.

2. Innovation and Use of Emerging Technologies (15%)

How innovative, creative and forward-thinking is the solution?

Judges will evaluate the originality of the approach and the effective use of emerging technologies such as Artificial Intelligence (AI), predictive analytics, intelligent automation, mobile technologies, advanced data analytics and other innovative approaches.

Solutions that advance South Africa's digital transformation agenda, promote local innovation, and demonstrate opportunities for building indigenous digital capability may score higher.

3. Technical Feasibility and Functionality (20%)

Does the solution work and is it technically sound?

Judges will assess the quality, completeness and functionality of the prototype, including system design, reliability, integration capability and overall technical implementation.

Solutions should demonstrate that key features operate as intended and show practical applicability within a government environment.

4. User Experience, Accessibility and Inclusivity (10%)

Is the solution usable, accessible and citizen-centred?

Judges will evaluate the user experience, interface design, accessibility considerations and ease of use. Solutions should cater for diverse users, including individuals with varying levels of digital literacy, persons with disabilities, and those operating in low-bandwidth or resource-constrained environments.

Particular consideration will be given to solutions that promote equitable access to digital services and improve outcomes for citizens.

Non-Executive Directors:

Prof Stella Bvuma (Chairperson), Ms. Siphumelele Dlungwane, Ms. Zimbini Hill, Ms. Nalini Maharaj, Mr. Willie Mathebula, Mr. Protas Phili, Mr. Rendani Ramabulana, Mr. Willie Vukela, Adv Johannes Collen Weapond

Executive Directors:

Mr. Magatho Mello (Managing Director), Ms. Yolande van Biljon (Chief Financial Officer)

Company Secretary:

Ms. Shirley Kgope (Acting)

5. Data, Intelligence and Insight Generation (10%)

How effectively does the solution leverage data and information?

Judges will assess how effectively the solution uses data, knowledge sources, analytics and AI capabilities to generate actionable insights, improve decision-making, enhance service delivery or empower users.

Solutions should demonstrate transparency, explainability and appropriate use of information and data sources.

6. Security, Governance and Responsible Technology Use (10%)

Does the solution demonstrate responsible and trustworthy use of technology?

Judges will evaluate how the solution addresses cybersecurity, privacy, data protection, responsible AI principles, transparency, accountability and human oversight where required.

Solutions should inspire confidence that they can be deployed safely, securely and ethically within the public sector.

7. Scalability, Sustainability and Digital Sovereignty (10%)

Can the solution be sustainably implemented and expanded beyond the hackathon?

Judges will assess the practicality, maintainability, scalability and interoperability of the solution.

Consideration will also be given to how the solution supports South Africa's digital sovereignty objectives through sustainable technology choices, open architectures where appropriate, local capability development, reduced dependency risks, and alignment with long-term public sector digital transformation priorities.

8. Presentation, Demonstration and Communication (5%)

Was the solution clearly presented and convincingly demonstrated?

Judges will assess the clarity of the presentation, quality of the demonstration, articulation of the value proposition, understanding of the problem, and the team's ability to respond to questions from the judging panel.

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